
Constructing the Enemy: Network Analysis of Anti-Hussite Vocabulary in Late Medieval Diplomatic Correspondence

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Abstract

Reading the correspondence between Grand Duke Vytautas of Lithuania, King Jogaila of Poland, Sigismund of Luxembourg, King of the Romans, Hungary and Bohemia, Pope Martin V, and the Grand Master of the Teutonic Order concerning the Hussites (1421–1430) (sources) reveals no discussion of the conceptual nature of heresy; the notion of hereticality is treated as self-evident, what is typical for ideological texts (Turunen 2024, 3–7). Instead, the 95 exchanged letters focus extensively on the harm caused by heretics and the urgent need for active measures against them. This study asks how rhetorical strategies of naming, denouncing, and delegitimising heretics are structured within this correspondence.

For a lexical co-occurrences network analysis (proven fruitful in Heretical Studies: Zbiral, Brys, and Hinz-Wieczorek 2024), six thematic word groups were selected: common anti-heretical vocabulary (red); rhetorical insults (green); disease/poison metaphors (purple); comparisons with other excluded groups (brown); actions to be taken against heretics (blue); and negative actions attributed to heretics (orange). As the letters were selected for containing heresis and its derivatives, these words were excluded from the network analyses. The method is limited by the need to exclude polysemous words that cannot be fully assigned to any group, for example, the root *conversio*. Also, *bellum* is excluded, since it could be any war (when *guerra* was used only as unjust heretical attacks and consequently included in the "orange" group). The lexical co-occurrence analysis (made by the Python script, Valodzina 2026) identified 1,536 non-zero word pairs, with a maximum edge weight of 15, and after filtering to retain only edges with weights greater than 5, the resulting core network consisted of 19 interconnected nodes representing the strongest lexical associations.

The results indicate that the dominant group is the precise actions imagined to be taken against heretics: from reduction to extermination. It is tightly interconnected with naming vocabulary ((heretical) errors) and typical rhetorical anti-heretical insults (*perfidia*, *pertinacia*, *obstinacio*, *damnacio*, *detestabile*, *deviatio*). The connection between *reduco* and *infamia* points to an additional socio-political dimension: the specific harm to secular rulers' reputations caused by their association with heresy. This conclusion is supported by the appearance, in the highly filtered results, of social concepts such as *societas* and *rebellis*, which eclipsed metaphors of disease and contagion.

This network of co-occurrences further demonstrates that anti-heretical discourse is structured around a core that links concrete descriptions of punitive actions to heretical threats

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to social stability, only at lower thresholds referencing specific groups such as the Hussites, Wycliffites or Thaborites. The Hussites appeared as a broadly connected yet weakly integrated node; at higher thresholds, however, they disappear entirely, indicating that they do not form part of the strongly bonded core. By contrast, the Thaborites persisted owing to stronger associations with specific acts of violence, particularly *incendia* (conflagrations), which are in turn linked to *effusio* (the shedding (of Christian blood)) and *clades* (harm).

The findings demonstrate that, rather than revealing personal religiosity, the correspondence constructs heresy not as a theological category, but as a network of actions, threats, and social consequences.

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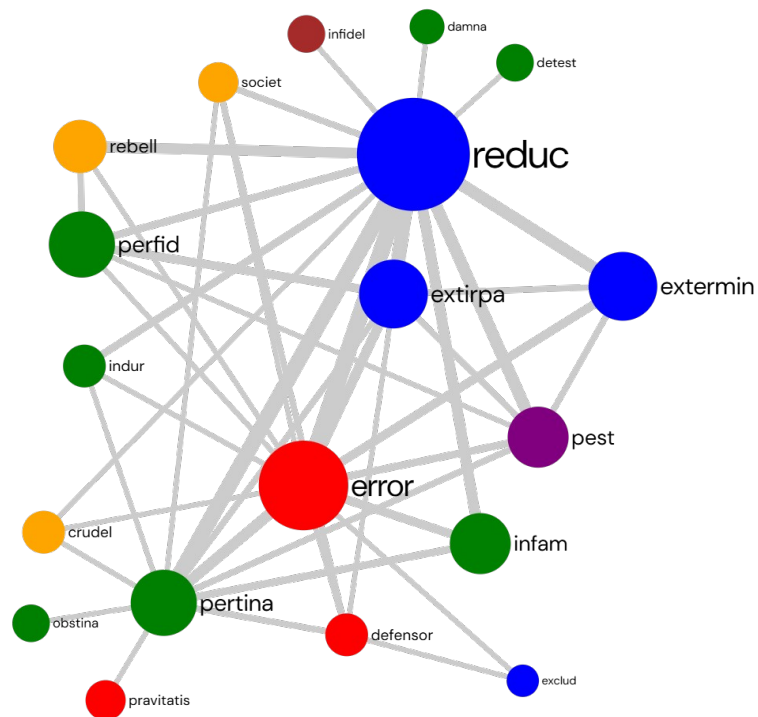


Figure 1. The colours of the groups correspond to the colours of the nodes.